

► Nativity horoscope

This horoscope of Prince Iskandar, the grandson of Tamerlane, the Mongol conqueror, shows the exact position of the stars and planets at the time of his birth on April 25, 1384.

fragrances, and offered magical recipes, including this one for brewing trouble: “Take four ounces of the blood of a black dog, two ounces each of pig blood and brains, and one ounce of donkey brains. Mix all this together until well blended. When you give this medicine to someone in food or drink, he will hate you.”

Astrological predictions

A key activity for astrologers was casting horoscopes to determine the ever-changing influence of stars and planets as they shifted position. The calculations of planetary movements were often mathematically complex, so most astrologers were respected scholars. There were four categories of horoscope in early Islamic astrology: nativities (maps of the influences in play at the time of a

birth); horoscopes for entire countries or dynasties; choices (to see whether it was a good time to take a particular action); and interrogations (to answer specific questions on topics as diverse as disease diagnosis and finding lost objects).

It was believed that one way to boost astrological influences was to make talismans, with different materials linked to specific astral factors. The idea was to choose the right material, usually metal, then make the talisman precisely when the right influence was calculated to be strongest.

◀ Stories in the stars

This manuscript of about 1300 is attributed to Abu Ma'shar. It contains illustrated discourses on many topics including demons, personified phases of the moon, and signs of the zodiac, such as this one on al-Saratan (Cancer).

IN CONTEXT

Modern astral magic

The *Picatrix* was widely studied in the West in the medieval era and after, including by Renaissance scholars such as Cornelius Agrippa and Marsilio Ficino and by numerous magical-mystical movements in the 19th century. In recent decades it has been read again by New Agers wishing to explore the notion of astral projection (see p.287)—the idea that it is possible to train the soul to pass into the plane of the stars and planets and their associated powers.



This modern talisman was made using the *Picatrix*'s instructions.

